Mapping Guru Nanak's Four Udasis

Geographical route breakdown, major stops, and missionary impact by region

Research position. The four-Udasi framework is a widely used Sikh tradition, but it is not a modern, independently verified itinerary. Guru Nanak's hymns are primary evidence for his authorship and teachings; travel details come mainly from later Janamsakhis, Bhai Gurdas's Vars, local traditions and route reconstruction. Britannica therefore treats visits to pilgrimage sites throughout India as certain, while warning that much beyond this is difficult to verify. [1]

This report uses the four-direction model for clarity. Some traditions count a fifth journey within Punjab, and early sources differ in how they combine or separate the east/south and north/west journeys. [1][2]

Udasi	Approximate traditional direction	Route spine	Representative major stops	Missionary emphasis
First: East	East and northeast across the Gangetic plain and Bengal/Assam	Sultanpur → Delhi/Panipat → Gangetic pilgrimage belt → Bengal/Assam → Puri → return via central and western India	Panipat, Delhi, Haridwar, Varanasi, Prayag, Gaya/Patna, Dacca, Kamrup/Assam, Jagannath Puri, Mathura, Kurukshetra	Dialogue with Hindu scholars and pilgrims; critique of empty ritual; affirmation of remembrance of the Divine Name, ethical action and human equality.
Second: South	South India and across the sea to Sri Lanka/Ceylon	Punjab → central/southern India → Rameshwaram/Setbandu → Sri Lanka → return through western/central India	Kanchipuram, Srirangam, Rameshwaram, Nagapattinam, Sri Lankan sites traditionally linked with the Guru, Ujjain, Somnath/Gujarat	Engagement with temple cultures, ascetics and local rulers; presentation of a universal spiritual message beyond sectarian boundaries.
Third: North	Himalayan and trans-Himalayan regions	Punjab → Himachal and Uttarakhand → Kashmir/Ladakh → Sumer Parbat tradition → return through Punjab	Kangra, Mandi, Kullu, Jwala Ji, Baijnath, Kashmir, Srinagar, Ladakh, Tibet/Kailash–Manasarovar in expanded traditions, Achal	Debates with Nath/Siddh ascetics; rejection of withdrawal from social responsibility; integration of devotion with family life, work and service.
Fourth: West	Sindh, Balochistan, Arabia, Iraq and Afghanistan	Punjab → Sindh/Balochistan → Mecca/Medina → Baghdad → Afghanistan → Punjab/Kartarpur	Multan, Uch, Hinglaj, Mecca, Medina, Baghdad, Kabul, Peshawar/Gorakhhatri, Hasan Abdal	Interfaith dialogue with Muslim scholars and Sufis; challenge to religious exclusivism; teaching that the Divine is not confined to a direction, place or community.

Route caution. The arrows above show a defensible geographical synthesis, not a GPS-like route. The Punjabi University atlas itself describes the reconstruction as difficult because no first-hand biography survives, the Janamsakhis vary, and local traditions must be used carefully. [2]

Detailed Regional Breakdown

1. First Udasi — East and Northeast

The traditional eastern journey begins at Sultanpur Lodhi and moves through the Punjab-Haryana–Delhi corridor into the major pilgrimage belt of north India. Frequently named stops include Panipat, Delhi, Hardwar, Varanasi, Prayag, Gaya and Patna/Hajipur. Expanded traditions continue toward Bengal, Dacca, Assam/Kamrup and then Jagannath Puri before the return journey. The atlas lists additional stops such as Gorakhmata/Nanakmata, Tanda, Gola, Ayodhya and Nizamabad. [2]

Regional impact: The region's missionary impact is represented in debates with ritual specialists and pilgrimage communities. The recurring message is that outward performance without inner truth is inadequate, and that truthful living, remembrance, humility and service are central.

2. Second Udasi — South and Sri Lanka

The southern route is often treated as a continuation of the first in some early traditions. It includes major South Indian centres such as Kanchipuram, Srirangam, Nagapattinam and Rameshwaram/Setbandu, followed by the traditional sea crossing to Ceylon, now Sri Lanka. The atlas records a return through Rameshwaram and western/central Indian sites including Ujjain, Gujarat and Rajasthan. [2]

Regional impact: The reported impact is not primarily territorial expansion. It is a pattern of public dialogue: Guru Nanak is portrayed as addressing priests, ascetics, householders and rulers in a language of one Divine Reality, moral conduct and equality across social boundaries.

3. Third Udasi — Himalayas and the North

The northern journey is associated with the Himalayan foothills, Kashmir and, in expanded route traditions, Ladakh and Tibet. The "Sumer Parbat" episode is especially important, but its geographical identification is debated. Mann notes that the Puratan account may refer to a site in the Punjab hills associated with Shaivite ascetics, while later interpretations identify it with the Kailash–Manasarovar region. [2]

Regional impact: The missionary theme is a direct challenge to extreme asceticism. In the narratives, conversations with Siddhs and Naths turn on whether spiritual attainment should mean abandoning ordinary life. The answer attributed to Guru Nanak emphasizes responsible household life, productive work and social commitment.

4. Fourth Udasi — West Asia and Afghanistan

The western route is traditionally the most internationally recognisable: through Sindh and Balochistan to Mecca and Medina, onward to Baghdad, and then through Afghanistan before returning to Punjab. The atlas names Multan, Uch, Lakhpat, Hinglaj, Mecca, Medina, Baghdad, Mashhad, Herat, Kandahar, Kabul and Peshawar among the associated places; its discussion also notes that Palestine, Syria and Turkey appear in some later accounts and that some modern writers extend the journey even farther, without definite supporting evidence. [2]

Regional impact: The route's core missionary impact is interfaith engagement. The Mecca narrative teaches divine omnipresence; the Baghdad tradition places Guru Nanak in conversation with Muslim spiritual authorities. These episodes should be read as religious narratives conveying theological and ethical lessons, not all as independently proven travel reports. [1][2]

Missionary Impact Across Regions

The journeys matter historically not only because of distance but because of the kind of religious encounter they represent. Mann's study argues that Guru Nanak's mission involved the formation of a distinct community with beliefs and institutional structures, rather than only the activity of a solitary mystic. [2]

Impact area	How the Udasis contributed
Interfaith conversation	The routes place Guru Nanak in contact—according to the traditions—with Hindu pandits, Nath/Siddh ascetics, Buddhist and Himalayan religious figures, and Muslim scholars/Sufis.
Equality and social critique	The narratives repeatedly oppose caste hierarchy, religious prestige without ethical conduct, and exclusion based on birth or ritual status.
Community formation	The Puratan tradition describes the Guru initiating followers, organizing congregations and appointing local authorities or manjis during the journeys. Mann presents this as evidence that institution-building was part of the mission. [2]
Portable message	Because the same core teachings recur across pilgrimage cities, villages, courts and Sufi centres, the mission is portrayed as adaptable to different cultures while remaining centred on one Creator, truthful living, remembrance, service and social responsibility.
Kartarpur as culmination	After the long journeys, Guru Nanak is traditionally said to have settled at Kartarpur, where congregational prayer, exposition of hymns, communal food and productive life formed a stable model for the emerging Sikh community. [2]

Method and Source Criticism

The chronology and route labels in this report follow the familiar four-Udasi framework for accessibility. The source record is more complex: the Puratan Janamsakhi, Meharban Janamsakhi, Bala Janamsakhi and Bhai Gurdas's Vars differ in their ordering, geography and theological elaboration. The Punjabi University atlas combines these texts with local traditions, historical routes and physical surveys, while openly acknowledging that the result is not final. [2]

For a factual presentation, the safest wording is "traditionally associated with" rather than "proved to have visited." The strongest historical claims concern Guru Nanak's own compositions, his Punjab base and his broad engagement with pilgrimage and religious communities; individual distant stops and exact dates require qualification. [1][2]

Selected Sources

[1] Encyclopaedia Britannica, “Guru Nanak,” by William Hewat McLeod, fact-checked by Britannica Editors, updated 25 Nov. 2025. Summarizes the historical limits of the Janamsakhis and the traditional east, south, north and west journeys.

[2] Gurinder Singh Mann, “Guru Nanak’s Life and Legacy: An Appraisal,” *Journal of Punjab Studies* 17, nos. 1–2, University of California, Santa Barbara. Discusses primary and early Sikh sources, the evolution of Janamsakhi traditions, the four long journeys in the Puratan account, and the institutional dimensions of Guru Nanak’s mission.

[3] Fauja Singh and Kirpal Singh, *Atlas: Travels of Guru Nanak*, Punjabi University, Patiala, 1976. Provides comparative maps and route reconstructions based on Bhai Gurdas, Puratan, Meharban and Bala traditions, supplemented by local traditions and historical route research.

Prepared as a research-oriented PDF brief. Dates and route sequences are intentionally not presented as certain where the sources do not support certainty.